holds some of us back. Even though I've been through it myself, it still crossed my mind once I'd got home after the World Cup in 2002: what would have been said and written about me if I'd missed that penalty against Argentina? I could be wrong. It's not something I've talked about with the other lads. I just have this sense that, in the really big games, a fear of failure sometimes stops us turning in the kind of performances we're capable of and which the fans want to see.

For whatever reason, Euro 2000 didn't go the way any of us would have wanted it to. Phil Neville took some of the blame for that. Kevin Keegan came in for a lot of criticism too. But with the team spirit that Kevin had created since coming in as England manager, we all felt we were in it together. And that meant all of us taking the responsibility for England getting knocked out so early on. Although we'd had a difficult time in qualifying, we still went off to the tournament expecting to do well. Before our arrival in Belgium and Holland, our training camp in France was much more relaxed than the one organized by Glenn Hoddle before the World Cup two years before. By the time the tournament began, everybody was really excited, and looking forward to getting started.

If you look at the opening twenty minutes of our first game that summer against Portugal in Eindhoven, you'd have to say we were in exactly the right shape and the right state of mind. They were an excellent team, with world-class players like Luis Figo and Rui Costa, and they put us under pressure straight away but every time we broke upfield we looked like we were going to score. I sent a couple of crosses in: Paul Scholes got on the end of the first one and Steve McManaman put in the second. We were 2–0 up before any of us had had time to feel how the game might be going. To be honest, we were surprised by the position we found ourselves in. We should have gone on to win the game but, almost straight away, Figo ran through and blasted one into the top corner and everything changed. Everything started to go wrong. They equalized just before half-time. Michael Owen went off injured, then Steve McManaman too. And the Portuguese got the winner in the second half.

For a neutral, it had been a great game. For us, though, and for the England supporters, it was really disappointing. To have been playing as well as we had early on, and to have scored two good goals but then let the game slip away, was unbelievably frustrating. The fact that we'd played some good soccer and been beaten by an excellent team didn't ease the pressure at all. Even though I thought I'd had a decent game, I felt really down at the end: losing 3–2 wasn't the start we'd been hoping for at all. For those few minutes after the final whistle I was off in a world of my own. Perhaps I should have